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YOUTHS FOR GREEN ACTION KENYA (YGAK)
NAROK COUNTY 100,000 TREE PLANTING REPORT



Theme: Future in a Million Trees

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT

The Youths for Green Action Kenya, NGO, acknowledges the fact that the success of Narok100000Tree campaign would not have been possible without the support of different individuals and teams. The organization sends its immense gratitude to its donors; German Imaging Technologies (GIT), Mount Meru Group, Victoria Furniture and individual philanthropists for their financial contribution during the project. Gratitude also goes to the organization partners like Narok County government, Ministry of Environment and Forestry, Kenya Forest Service (KFS), Kenya Wildlife Service (KWS), NEMA, Rapid Deployment Unit (RDU Narok county), the local community leadership led by Chief. Pulei for their logistical support during the project. Special gratitude goes to partner higher learning institutions; Egerton University, Masinde Muliro University of Science & Technology, Technical University of Kenya, Multimedia University, Kenyatta University, Jomo Kenyatta University of Agriculture & Technology for support the project not just with buses for transportation but also allowing their students to volunteer for the project. The organization greatly acknowledges the volunteers for their sacrifices and selflessness to attend the project and ensure its success. Above all, the organization give thanks to Almighty God for enabling planning and successful completion of this project.

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INTRODUCTION

High-level debates in environmental councils may sometimes seem divorced from grassroots issues. Today, Youths for Green Action Kenya, NGO, a wholly youth-led organization literally looks at grassroots where environmental championship and climate action is needed the most. **“Dirty hands, clean environment”** is not a metaphor but rather a reality that the youths have embraced. In today’s world, in the middle of economic complexities, we all need steady reminders of our connection with mother nature. This act is vital. A healthy planet is directly linked to human health and welfare without forgetting the future generation, and trees form an essential part of it. Trees play a critical role in mitigating climate change impact and thus are necessary contributions to the health of the planet acting as its lungs, drawing in carbon dioxide and breathing out oxygen.

On May 22nd -28th, 2023, Youths for Green Action Kenya, NGO, in the frames of **“Future in a Million Trees”** planting project, sets out to regenerate the lost biodiversity in Chebitat, Mau forest in Narok county. Based on the belief and cooperative value of unity, this young organization embark on a journey to plant **100,000 trees** in **Mau forest** a once inhabited forest land to help bring back its lost glory after the evacuation of the settlers. This campaign is a manifestation that youths can be a part of something greater, sustaining the environment and developing a greener economy in the middle of climate change crisis.

THE NAROK 100,000 TREES PROJECT HIGHLIGHT

The **Narok100000Trees** campaign brought about 200 volunteers from across different **universities** in the country (Egerton university, Masinde Muliro University of Science & Technology, Technical University of Kenya, Jomo Kenyatta University of Agriculture & Technology, Multimedia University), 100 local community volunteers (including scouts), **donors** from different companies (German Imaging Technologies, Dubai, Mount Meru Group, Dubai, Victoria Furniture, Kenya, and individual philanthropists), partners from different **government institutions** (Kenya Forest Service, Kenya Wildlife Service, African Youth Leadership Forum, EMA, Kenya Red cross Society, Narok County Government, and Ministry of Environment Kenya), **media** and the **local community**.



On May 22nd 2023, Youths for Green Action Volunteers arrive at Chebitat camping site, a place where they would camp for 6 days to accomplish their mission of restoring Mau forest by planting 100,000 trees. Energetic, happy and determined faces are expressed among all of them with the hope of leading environmental change. From a far, empty spaces in the forest land can be noticed, but this would be filled by 100,000 trees in the next six days.

OPENING CEREMONY

The official opening of the 6-day tree planting campaign was conducted on 23rd May 2023. The event was graced by different partners from higher learning institutions, government officials and donors. In attendance was:

- Dr. Khatib Sassan, founder and CEO of German Imaging Technologies (GIT)-Dubai,
- Mr. Vishwal representing Mount Meru Group
- Prof. Alice Ndiema (Registrar, Planning Research and Innovation also representing the DVC Planning Research & Innovation-MMUST),
- Dr. James Owuor (Chair Greening Initiative-MMUST),
- Mr. Oscar Waswa (Assistant Registrar Student Affairs Department MMUST),
- Mr. Pulei (local community Chief) & Mr. James Ole Nakola (County Youth Coordinator)
- YGAK Board officials led by Mr. Yusuf Sigel and
- YGAK Executive office led by Mr. Denis Asiya (CEO).

"Climate change has thrown everybody off-balance, we are proud that the youths have designed a program to enable agroforestry," Prof. Alice Ndiema-Registrar Planning Research & Innovation, MMUST



"The youths have engaged the local community to ensure there is harmony in the fight against climate change," Mr. Pulei, area chief



"The world has seen the number of trees shrinking in our forests, and we are here to support YGAK in their drive to plant 1million trees in the next 4 years," Dr. Sassan Khatibu, CEO-GIT



"As individuals, we must do what we can to make a difference. Just like the little Hummingbird, we must use our sight to protect what we have," Mr. Asiya, CEO-YGAK



"Our responsibility as higher learning institutions is to ensure we design & lobby for the implementation of policies that will drive the greening agenda in ways that are meaningful & productive to our communities," Prof. Charles Mutai, DVC Planning research & Innovation-MMUST



Ceremonial Tree Planting during the Opening Ceremony



TREE PLANTING (100,000)

Youths for Green Action Kenya, NGO, was allocated 110 acres of land in Chebitat forest, to push its regeneration and conservation agenda. The organization was specifically allotted Plot No. 23 in the Mau forest land. Volunteers engaged in planting trees every morning with a target of at least 60 tree seedlings per person per day which the volunteers embraced so well with different donors happily joining in the activity. The sloppy terrain in the forest did not hinder the volunteers who were excitedly determined to accomplish their daily targets.



Mau



YOUTH LEADERSHIP & GOVERNANCE TRAINING

Escaping climate change, and breaking through the inertia associated with climate change action is a reality that has been given a global priority from all governments, businesses and interest

organizations. Climate change has also created the need to develop environmental leaders with societal beneficial roles as a response to this global crisis. Amazing, the concepts of environmental leadership, and as realized by many experienced environmental leaders, is that environmental and social issues permeate virtually all area boundaries within an organization and its activities. This is why environmental leadership becomes a very vital activity in shaping the youths to become environmental leaders. Youths for Green Action Kenya volunteers were trained on leadership starting with recognizing the importance of diversity in teams as the planting activity revolved majorly on working as a team to attain a common goal.

Conducted by **African Youth Leadership Forum (AYLF)**, the first leadership training began with learning **SASHET**, a connection tool that a team could use to gain a deeper connection of how the team members feel, how they are heard and valued. This tool allows openness and clear communication among team members giving a feeling of comfort and understanding. The volunteers



were also taken through **7 Habits of an Effective Leader** based on Dr. Stephen Coveys principles. The 7 habits included; Habit 1 – Be proactive, Habit 2 – Begin with the End in Mind, Habit 3 – Put First Things First, Habit 4 – Think Win/Win, Habit 5 – Seek first to Understand, then to be understood, Habit 6 – Synergize, and Habit 7 – Sharpening the Saw. These habits help give a sense of direction, helping in time management, prioritizing activities, developing the discipline to manage oneself and relating with others in a team.



"If we try to work on our attitudes and behaviors we can make some small improvements in our lives and character," Mr. Robinson
Njoroge -AYLF

By Mr. Gedion Letaya, the volunteers were also educated on ways to get involved in leadership and governance, including; Getting involved in community activities to enable people notice them, promoting personal development, engaging with the community where possible, never ignoring small impacts they make as everything starts small, discovering areas of strength and focusing on them, finding what makes them unique and respecting the leadership in place.

CULTURAL DIVERSITY EDUCATION

The volunteers were taught the Maasai culture, including the Maasai historical background, the cultural norms, community leadership, cultural foods, initiation and marriage culture. The volunteers also engaged in the Maasai cultural dance as a way to embrace the diversity that we were getting into during the week.

TEAM BUILDING

“Team work makes the dream work,” a phrase that reminds us that we can overcome the biggest obstacles if we share a common goal and work as a team to achieve it. Team building sessions (involving hiking, dancing, cooking together, exercise and games and Maasai Mara game drive) were meant to make the volunteers bond together, acquaint with each other, build each other’s strengths and appreciate weaknesses working towards improving them. As said by Andrew Carnegie, *“...It is the fuel that allows common people to attain uncommon results.”* These exercises were meant to build motivation and increase productivity among the volunteers. They provided opportunities for the volunteers to interact, learn from each other and appreciate one another.





CLOSING CEREMONY

The closing ceremony recognized the collective efforts of all the stakeholders who came together to enable the success of the **Narok100000Trees** project. Conducted on 27th May 2023, the organization acknowledged the support of all the donors, partner institutions, facilitators from different organizations, volunteers and the local community for their coordination to achieve the project target. Recognitions and awards were issued to different stakeholders by the organization.



"We look forward to more partnerships with YGAK in their future projects to ensure the we both work towards climate change mitigation," Miss Lydia-Victoria Furniture

ENCOUNTERS DURING THE PROJECT

As with any project, there may be few challenges that may hinder complete success of a project, and Narok100000Trees project was not an exception. A large number of volunteers were getting the camping experience for the first time, with the forest colds in the morning, it may have been difficult for a number of them to navigate through the forest cold and sloppy terrain during the planting. This however was embraced by the volunteers making it exciting as could be heard from volunteers shouting '*Brother Bernard*', whenever one would slip.

CONCLUSION

The success of Narok100000Trees project was a joint effort of different but like-minded individuals who share a vision of achieving a sustainable future. This project act as a benchmark for the organization to achieve higher targets in its subsequent projects. Aligned to the Sustainable Development Goals, the organization hopes to create more impact in order to build a future that everyone would admire (a pollution free future, a future with lower mean temperatures and a greener future).

RECOMMENDATION

Achieving environmental sustainably lies in the shoulders of every individual. We acknowledge that our individual actions put together have contributed to the climate crisis we witness today. We therefore call upon every individual in whichever capacity, to participate in the journey of environmental conservation and climate change mitigation.

PHOTO GALLERY





APPENDIX: YOUTHS FOR GREEN ACTION KENYA, CONCEPT NOTE

Introduction

The environment has limited natural resources with fragile life-support systems, and thus, can carry limited amount of burden. However, in the quest for economic progress and welfare, it is the environment that more often, gets compromised. Wide scale environmental degradation is the consequent result of society's insatiable appetite for growth and development. There is an urgent need to balance growth and development without putting a lot of burden on environmental resources.

Youths for Green Action Kenya was thus established in 2018 to be an organization of the youth and for the youth in championing environmental conservation and help protect the environment. This organization was previously known as Youths Action Kenya NGO which was later in 2021 changed to Youths for Green Action Kenya and registered under section 10 of the Non-Governmental Organizations Co-ordination Board of Kenya. YGAK aims at capacity building youths and communities to promote environmental management and conservation. This has been achievable through engaging in programs/projects and activities that create environmental awareness and education.

The Youths for Green Action Kenya, NGO, is a wholly youth-led organization seeking to position the youths at the center of environmental action. The organization believes that the youths have the capacity to drive change with regards to climate action agenda. The organization ensures collaborative engagement with other organizations, institutions of higher learning, corporate organizations and individuals towards promoting environmental conservation.

Mission

We are dedicated to environmental improvements that foster a sustainable future and leads to social and economic empowerment in our communities.

Vision statement

We envision a clean, healthy, safe and sustainable environment in Kenya and beyond

Aim

- i. To promote conservation and sustainable use of environment

- ii. To promote the culture of community philanthropy and volunteerism among the youths

Major thematic areas

- i. Environmental education, research, awareness and outreach
- ii. Conservation leadership

FOCUS

Our major focus is achieving a sustainable environment by ensuring that the natural systems can continue to provide the natural resources and ecosystem services upon which the economy and society depend. We understand this is a process and we focus on approaching it from local and regional levels with emphasis on the environment.

METHODOLOGY

Focus is given to outreach projects and activities in our communities that aim at greening the environment; tree planting, solid waste management and creating environmental awareness. For all our established projects, we conduct follow up routines to ensure efficiency and long term impacts. We empower community generated projects through partnership to ensure maximum incorporation of community players in operations. Philanthropy stands out as a main vehicle towards promoting the well-being of humanity and cultivate the spirit of one society and its ability to solve its challenges.

IMPACT

We have had successful projects focused on building community resilience towards addressing challenges posed by climate change. We have carried out tree planting, youth leadership workshops, Environmental education in primary and high schools and stakeholder's meetings in the theme.

We have successfully planted over 79,000 tree seedlings in the Counties of Narok, Nakuru, Mombasa, Kakamega and Kisumu within three years of partnership, and collected over 10 tons of wastes in our different cleanup activities. Having been able to partner with different institutions, organizations and individuals, has helped us gear towards achieving our goals and objectives. The organization so far has also reached out to a million people through our activities and on our social media platforms.

Youths for Green Action Kenya is targeting to plant over 100,000 tree seedlings yearly, and making higher learning institutions in Kenya clean by collecting wastes. We anticipate to further

reach out to the less fortunate individuals or groups in our society through quarterly donations. The organization targets to build strong partnership with institutions and other organizations that promotes its agenda, as well as providing guidance

SUCCESSFUL PROJECTS CONDUCTED

1. Mombasa Project (Theme: *Action for sustainable city and community*)

Conducted in 10th-14th January 2022, YGAK in partnership with the County Government of Mombasa and Egerton University carried out a community service in Bangladesh slums and Bangladesh Mangrove creek working closely with the Bangladesh elites Community Based Organizations, Linda



Mikoko Self Help Group and Big Ship Community Based Organization. Activities conducted included; clean up and sensitization of the community to promote community based environmental action, planting of 500 Mangrove trees along Bangladesh Mangrove site, capacity building workshop on climate action, and career and skills development.

2. Kakamega Project (Theme: *Future in a Million Trees*)

The Organization partnered with German Imaging Technologies (GIT), County Government of Kakamega, National Environment Management Authority (NEMA) and Masinde Muliro University of Science and Technology (MMUST) in an effort to improve rural, school and urban



environmental conditions and to educate and empower local communities on environmental concerns. The project was carried out between 26th-29th May, 2022 with external funding from German Imaging Technologies (GIT). Trees were planted in three sub-counties; Shinyalu, Ikolomani, and Lorambi. the specific targeted sites included Shitoli Polytechnic and Kambiri

Community in Shinyalu Sub-County, St Jerome Savane Polytechnic in Ikolomani and Bondeni primary in Lurambi Sub-County. A total of 10,000 tree seedlings were planted; 4000 Indigenous trees, 5700 exotic trees and 300 fruit trees.

3. World Environment Day (Theme: *Only One Earth*)

Youths for Green Action Kenya volunteers on 5th June 2022 joined the County Government of Nakuru Department of Environment and Natural Resources and other stakeholders in making the World Environment Day. On this day, the organization together with other partners planted 5,000 trees in Menengai forest. The celebration was graced by Nakuru county Environment Chief Officer as the guest of honor.

4. August Tree Planting Challenge YGAK conducted a one-month tree planting challenge in the month of August 2022 ahead of the Kisumu project. This was one of the measures to increase the forest tree cover in Kenya. The campaign tasked YGAK ambassadors with planting trees in their respective residences, neighboring public spaces, and any other spots that they felt were appropriate for planting trees in their individual home counties. There was an open invitation to all ambassadors and all the participants were urged to invite their friends, family, and neighbors to attend and participate in the planting sessions with them. The challenge saw 1025 trees being planted in different regions of the country.



5. Kisumu Project

The County Government of Kisumu has committed to plant 40 million tree seedlings to help achieve the national afforestation agenda of planting at least 2 billion trees by 2022. To achieve this, the organization joined the commitment by the Kisumu county government by planting a total of 1000 tree seedlings within Kisumu town between 28th-30th October 2022. The organization planted trees in various institutions including, Kenya Medical Training College-Kisumu main campus, Joyland Secondary school, Citam School Kisumu, ACK Shauri Moyo ward, and finally at The Mosque of Jesus Christ son of Mary. The organization attracted diverse partners including Kisumu County Government-environmental Department, YGAK- volunteers from Masinde Muliro University, Kenyatta university, Egerton university, the Technical

university of Kenya, technical university of Mombasa, Kenya Medical Training College- Kisumu main campus, Joyland special school, Citam Kisumu, ACK shauri Moyo, and The Mosque of Jesus Christ Son of Mary.

6. Run for the Mau

This is an annual event organized by Egerton University for the rehabilitation of Njoro River. The organization partnered with the university and other cooperate organization in ensuring a commitment towards rehabilitation of the river. The organization committed to plant 1000 trees to facilitate the event which were planted on 7th April 2023.



OTHER ACTIVITIES

The organization has engaged in different capacity building activities/workshops to ensure that the volunteers are up to date with the current environmental trends. We have also been nominated to environmental champion competitions like the Hummingbird Awards where we won different tree seedlings and seed-balls to help foster our mission. Bringing the volunteers together through different occasions like climate action seminars, teambuilding activities, workshops and talks has been key to ensure that we keep up with our enthusiasm.

GLANCE IMPACT

- Conducted 20 projects
- Planted 200,000 trees in different parts of the country
- Collaboration- On boarded the following partners: German Imaging Technologies, Watu Credit, Egerton university, NEMA, county governments, Kenya Forest Services
- Monitoring and Evaluation- we monitored and evaluated the impact of the initiatives and projects carried out during the year. This we believe will help the organization understand what is working well and what can be improved to achieve its goals more effectively
- Creation of Awareness - The NGOs has invested its efforts on raising awareness on environmental issues among the public especially in schools. We believe this will help

build support for the NGOs initiatives and increase its impact.



YGAK in Statehouse Primary School



YGAK in Akuisi Secondary School

CHALLENGES

- Limited resources, including funding and equipment makes it difficult for the organization to carry out its initiatives and projects effectively. The organization however has been keen in forming constructive collaborations quickly whenever they want to carry out a project to facilitates its smooth running. The organization continues to call upon more partners who support their agenda to help them achieve its goals.
- Limited public awareness among YGAK ambassadors. Despite the efforts by the organization to raise awareness of its activities, the general public is still not well-informed of its operations.

FUNDING

The organization sources its funds from grants and project funds, donations and gifts, members' contribution, and income generating activities like tree seedling selling to run its activities.

STRUCTURE OF ADMINISTRATION

Board of Directors

Chief Executive Officer

Executive Committee

Volunteers

MEMBERSHIP

Our constitution provides membership under various categories open to Youths worldwide and corporations willing to help further our Agenda. As of May 2023, the total number of registered

members are 292. We are targeting to have more than 1,000 registered members. Our membership coverage is across the country (Kenya) with more than 6 higher learning education institutions, Egerton University, Jomo Kenyatta University of Science & Technology, Kenyatta University, Maasai Mara University, Masinde Muliro University of Science & Technology, Technical University of Kenya



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